

What is it?

It is one of Rakesh Goyal's most memorable cases. He recalls when one of India's well-known banks received a complaint from a clerk, stating that there may have been an accounting error in the charge of interest rates on overdrawn accounts. A few accounts showed the charge to be just 5 per cent, when the bank's charge was 10 per cent. The resulting difference ran into several lakhs of rupees. The tedious task of checking all records was done and nothing seemed amiss. Yet the money was missing. This is the point at which Rakesh Goyal's firm, *Sysman*, was called in. His firm specialises in the detection of cyber crimes.

They stumbled across the possible tool of attack when they ran a check through the 259 programs that the bank used. In this list they found nine programs that were not in the official list of software. On testing them, it was found that three of them accessed the database and produced no audit trail. The firm came up with the hypothesis that someone could have briefly reset the interest rates. The only possible time that these alien programs could have got into the bank's network was when they did their last upgrade. This helped them zero in on the day of the attack. This also helped identify the accounts involved. The officer staffing a particular desk was questioned. They put him in a room, asked him a few questions and he cracked. It didn't take much of an effort to make the man talk once the heavy-lifting of studying the systems was complete.

Simply put, computer/cyber security is the science of protecting the data residing on our computer systems and networks from unauthorised access, disclosure, transfer and modifications, whether accidental or intentional. It could be as simple as installing an anti-virus program on your desktop to installing firewalls and honeypots at the network level. It could also be the task of tracing the crime, such as the above example.

Why is it needed?

Just as each stride ahead in this information age enables us to transfer information more freely and have better and faster access to knowledge, security of this information also becomes a key issue. Computer security is required at all levels — personal, corporate, state or country. Protecting data in today's environment has become a greater concern and a formidable task to undertake.

A cyber-criminal or hacker could strike in many different ways. He could

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